



EMPATHY: THE PURSUIT OF JOY – A HERO'S JOURNEY



A DOCUMENTARY FILM *EXPERIENCE*
WITH THE POWER TO HEAL YOUR MIND, BODY AND SOUL

THE B.I.G. IDEA

Life happens. The Beautiful. The Brutal. The Inbetween. Loneliness, anxiety and stress are at an all time high.



And at the same time.... Our soul's desire is wired for connection... But our brain is wired for protection.

And the mind can turn into a prison. But what if it didn't have to be? It's not what happens, that defines us. It's how we respond. What if the lock and key is within? What if there was Ancient Wisdom, Proven by Science that you could use in your life? And elixir to unlock the mind?

THE SURPRISING DISCOVERY: THE FILM'S SECRET

The secret is the Power of Perspective. The key to unlock the mind? And the doors of perception? Empathy. That's when magic happens. This is a true story of ordinary hero's who master mind over matter and from the stories we tell ourselves to pull off the greatest escape. And in the process, we discover we are more alike than we are not.

Whether you are a monk, a maximum-security prisoner, a rock star or the rest of us... these stories give us a glimpse of possibility. If they can do this, you can do anything.

THE SCIENCE

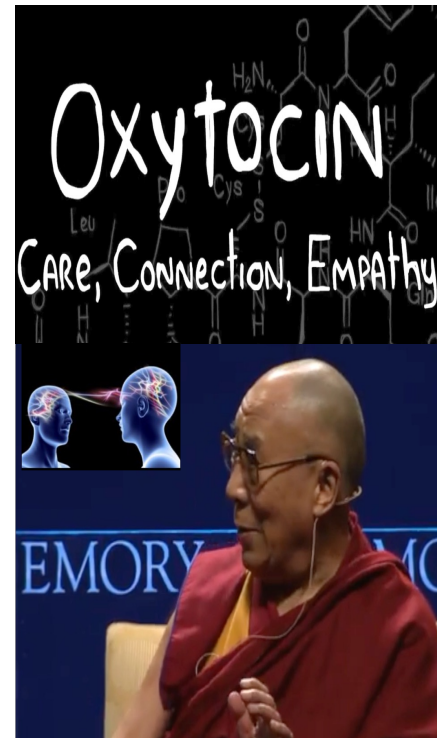
Most people don't know the Dalai Lama is a big fan of science. He's been collaborating with key neuroscientists from Columbia, Harvard, Wisconsin & Emory University for over 25 years to measure the effects of ancient Tibetan wisdom.

He sent his top Monk to Emory University to build a science and compassion measurement center. They have trained over 77 M people, in 24 countries in 23 languages in compassion and empathy practices. The results? Not only dramatic, positive outcomes in psychological factors like stress, depression, anxiety but also anti-stress biomarkers.

In our story, experts from these key research institutions help us understand our brains and why empathy makes it better. Hint? When our human brain faces uncertainty and scary things, it activates a stress responses associated with cortisol and defensive survival behaviors—fight, flight, freeze, or fawn.

Empathy, however, is associated with oxytocin and neurochemicals that support trust, connection, self-regulation, and co-regulation. They are the neurochemical elixir that opens the doors of perception to shift the brain's perception – we can see challenges as opportunities, and forward movement.

The film reframes **empathy** not as sentiment or weakness, but as a **measurable, trainable human capacity** that changes how the brain interprets reality itself.



THE SONICS

Our original sound bath soundtrack and score is meant to heal you while you listen. Led by multi-platinum recording artist Maejor, along with Tibetan artists, monks and nuns and a global group of neuro-acoustic musicians and students from the Dalai Lama's Dharmshala middle school, we are cultivating the ancient wisdom into a sonic elixir and *neuro-scientifically-based, multi-sensory experience* meant to shift your mood, your outlook and mind.



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EMPATHY IS THE NEW MEDITATION – HERE'S WHY

When the Maharishi Mahesh first brought meditation to the West, it didn't stick. He repositioned it as a universal, scientific, and non-religious mental practice to improve well being – one that could be studied, measured and integrated into modern life. This reframing led to massive adoption by celebrities, medical institutions, and scientists, with massive mainstream appeal.

While the Dalai Lama's main message is about compassion, we found there was a fundamental missing and unknown step. This film builds on that same type of translational momentum. The missing link? Surprisingly, empathy! We reframe empathy from a misunderstood emotion to a scientifically measurable core human technology for a better brain and a better life. And who wouldn't want that!?

And where meditation helped Western audiences access inner stillness, this film explores empathy as the next necessary measurable human capacity that allows individuals to regulate stress, navigate challenges, become proactive – resulting in resilience, compassion and joy.

HOW WE TELL THIS STORY

This is not a film about becoming a monk, changing religion, or retreating from the world. It is about learning to meet life differently—where curiosity replaces judgment, and a simple question, *"Tell me more..."*, becomes a powerful nervous-system pattern interrupt.

The film culminates in a special message from His Holiness the Dalai Lama, honoring the ripple effect of compassionate leadership while grounding the message in practical, human application.

Our human-centered storytelling addresses one of the most urgent challenges of our time: how humans regulate fear, rise to challenges, find meaning, and reconnect in an increasingly fragmented world.

This is not a faith-based film, nor a wellness trend piece. It's a cinematic, science-informed, self-help exploration meant to give people agency, freedom and help them connect to their inner joy, and increase their resilience.

WHAT'S DIFFERENT?

This project introduces a unique five-element storytelling architecture:

1. **Buddhist Wisdom Traditions** – practical insight into suffering and resilience
2. **Jungian Psychology** – shadow, meaning, and individuation
3. **Joseph Campbell's Hero's Journey** – narrative transformation
4. **Modern Neuroscience** – proof-based understanding of why ancient wisdom works
5. **Empathy (The Elixir)** – the integrative force that enables perception to shift

Empathy is the connective tissue that allows these frameworks to function together—making transformation accessible rather than abstract.

OUR IMPACT PHILANTHROPY

- Sponsoring children in exile
- Building a recording studio for students
- Including the student's music in the film

WHY NOW

Global anxiety, loneliness, and emotional disconnection are at historic highs. Former U.S. Surgeon General reports show loneliness carries health risks comparable to smoking 15 cigarettes a day.

This film arrives at a moment of profound cognitive dissonance—offering audiences not escape, but **relief through understanding**. It invites viewers to feel better *and* to participate in a broader cultural shift toward emotional intelligence, resilience, and connection.

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CREATIVE LEADERSHIP

Dr. Natalie Petouhoff

Executive Producer, Writer, Story Architect

Dr. Natalie Petouhoff is a Wall Street Journal bestselling author, Ph.D. scientist, and empathy strategist. Her work blends neuroscience, leadership, and ancient wisdom to create measurable emotional and transformation. Her book *Empathy in Action* earned 15 industry awards and established her as a leading voice on empathy as both a human and economic advantage.

As the emotional architect of the film, Natalie curates voices across disciplines—neuroscience, music, psychology, contemplative practice—and weaves them into a coherent narrative that mirrors the hero's journey itself.



Josh Sikkema

Director, Cinematographer & Creative Visionary

Josh Sikkema is an award-winning director and cinematographer whose work bridges music, narrative storytelling, and social impact. His debut short film *Something in the Clouds* earned 8 festival wins and 21 official selections. His collaborations span artists including Snoop Dogg, Mýa, Stokley, and producers Jimmy Jam and Terry Lewis—contributing to over one billion streams worldwide.

With roots in NBC news production, Josh brings precision, emotional depth, and profound respect for the human experience to every frame. Named to *Crain's Michigan 40 Under 40*, he continues to push cinematic boundaries while centering empathy, resilience, and truth.



Maejor

Musical Director, Sonic Healing Frequency Architect

Maejor is a multi-platinum, Grammy-nominated recording artist, producer, and composer whose work bridges mainstream music, neuroscience, and healing sound. Known for producing Billboard Top 100 hits and collaborating with global artists including Justin Bieber, Drake, Ciara, Monica, Trey Songz, and Nelly, Maejor brings both cultural reach and deep intentionality to sound.

Maejor serves as the film's Musical Director, designing a sonic architecture informed by emerging neuro-acoustic research, sacred geometry of sound, and ancient Tibetan tonal traditions. His work explores how rhythm, frequency, and harmony influence emotional regulation, attention, and meaning-making.

Maejor has created immersive sound experiences for large-scale cultural venues including *Van Gogh: The Immersive Experience* and Six Flags Magic Mountain's *Vibration Forest* and is the founder of the Frequency Music School in Switzerland, where youth are taught to cultivate emotional resilience through music.



His podcast *Maejor Frequency*, named Adweek's Podcast of the Year, features leading scientists, artists, and thinkers exploring why sound is one of humanity's most universal tools for connection and healing.

SCIENTIFIC NEURO-AOCUSTIC MUSIC AND MEASUREMENT ADVISORY BOARD

To ensure rigor, credibility, and ethical integrity, the project is guided by a multidisciplinary **Scientific Advisory Board**, including experts in neuroscience, psychology, contemplative science, and human-centered AI.

Advisors support:

- Validation of neuroscience concepts presented in the film
- Review of language to ensure scientific accuracy
- Development of post-film impact measurement
- Translation of research into accessible, responsible storytelling



Jason Snell



Kimi Doan



Paul Zak, PhD



Jessizza-Pade



Paul Edge, PhD



Kirsty Allan, PhD



Dr. Thompson



Kelly Bollman



Jacob Marshal